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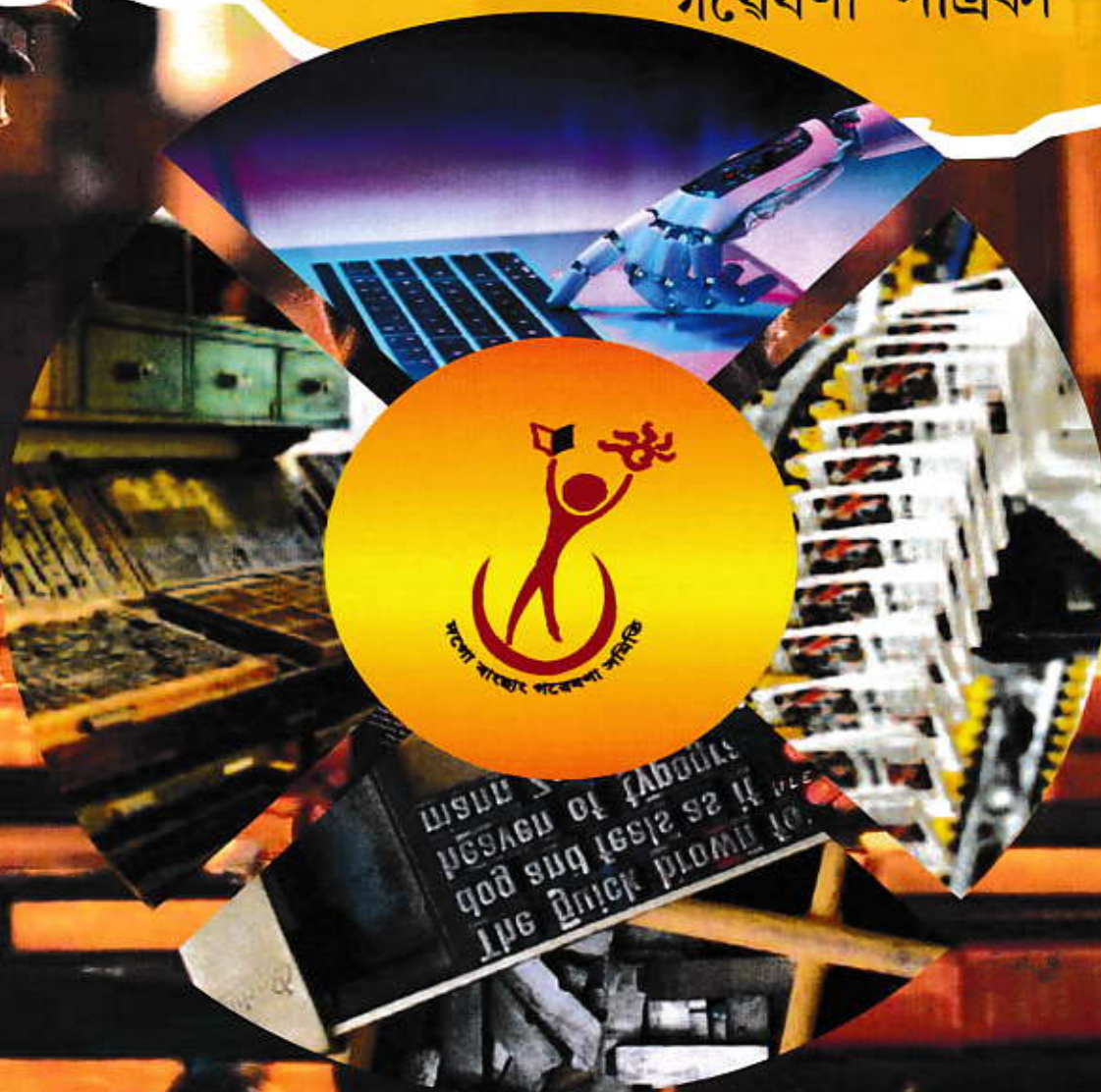
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**ROLE OF NGOS IN PROMOTING SUSTAINABLE RURAL DEVELOPMENT IN INDIA :
AN ANALYSIS**

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Abstract

Non-governmental organizations have emerged as an important element of contemporary Indian society and alike between in the grassroots and civil society. During the last one and half decade there has been a great deal of interest in the voluntary sector. NGOs in recent days have taken lion's share in promoting and implementing different development activities. Non-government organizations as a third sector institutional framework are playing a crucial role in providing strong support to the development issues. In recent times, responding to Grass-roots level initiative and voluntary action became necessary to develop the rural areas. NGOs should encourage the rural people with the method of participatory rural appraisal and awareness activities. The government should take more interest and improve rural development with the help of NGOs. In this direction, the government should give support to NGOs.

Key Words : NGOs, Indian society, Civil society, Sustainable, Rural Development.

Introduction:

NGOs play a crucial role in the rural development. Hence rural development is concerned with economic growth & social justice, improvement in the living standard of the rural people by providing adequate and quality social services & minimum basic needs becomes essential. Therefore, the concept of sustainability of rural development is gaining momentum from last few years. The concept of 'Sustainability' focuses on poverty alleviation, better livelihood opportunities, provision of basic amenities and infrastructure facilities through innovative programmes of wage and self-employment. Though many steps have taken by the government, it is observed that government programs have not succeeded up to the mark. Hence NGOs are emerging as a new thrust for the sustainability of rural development. Through this paper an attempt has been made to analyze the contribution of NGOs for the sustainable rural development in India.

HISTORY OF NGOS:

International non-governmental organizations have a history back to 1839. It has been estimated that by 1914, there were 1083 NGOs. International NGOs were important in the anti-slavery movement and the movement for women's suffrage, and reached a peak at the time of the World Disarmament Conference. The World Health Organizations first made the term NGO popular back in 1945. There are more than 50,000 International NGOs. Rapid development of the non-governmental sector occurred in Western Countries as a result of the processes of restructuring of the welfare state. Further globalization of the process occurred after the fall of the communist system & was an important part of the Washington consensus. Globalization during the 20th century gave rise to the importance of NGOs. Many problems could not be solved within a nation. International treaties & International Organizations such as the WTO were centered mainly on the interests of capitalist enterprises. In an attempt to counterbalance this trend, NGOs have developed to emphasize humanitarian issues, developmental aid & sustainable development.

NGOs with their advantage of service have established multitude of roles which can effect rural development. In the cases in which NGOs are funded totally or partially by governments, the NGO maintains its non-governmental status by excluding government representatives from membership in the organization.

CONCEPT OF NGOS:

NGOs are difficult to define and classify, and the term 'NGO' is not used consistently. As a result, there are many different classifications in use. The most common use a framework that includes

orientation and level of operation. An NGO's orientation refers to the type of activities it undertakes. These activities might include human rights, environmental, or development work. An NGO's level of operation indicates the scale at which an organization works, such as local, international or national. According to the UN, any kind of private organization that is independent from government control can be termed an "NGO", provided it is not-profit, non-criminal and not simply an opposition political party.

Professor Peter Willetts from the University of London argues the definition of NGOs can be interpreted differently by various organizations and depending on a situation's context. He defines an NGO as "'an independent voluntary association of people acting together on a continuous basis for some common purpose other than achieving government office, making money or illegal activities.'" Professor Akira Iriye defines NGO as "a voluntary non state, nonprofit, nonreligious and nonmilitary association." A **non-governmental organization** is a legally constituted organization created by natural or legal persons that operates independently from any form of government.

VISIONS AND MISSION OF NGOs:

NGOs in India are committed to social justice, sustainable development and human rights. The right to communicate freely is a basic human right and a necessity for sustainable development. Access to information is essential to informed decision-making at all levels. NGOs in India are committed to the dissemination of information and promotion of sustainable development initiatives, in response to the needs of underrepresented and marginalized sectors of society. For bridging the data gap and improving information availability NGO network is committed to develop and establish an ideal medium for the Participation and exchange of a trusted and accurate source of quality information.

AIMS AND OBJECTIVES OF NGOs:

The objectives of NGOs reveal the range of their goals, ideals, programmes and activities. Regarding the aims and objectives, the NGOs are broad-based and each NGO combines more than one objective. These objectives cover a wide spectrum of subjects like socio-economic development, empowerment of women, development of rural folks, trials, environmental protection, literacy, rehabilitations of the needy, awareness programmes, poverty alleviation, leadership training consumer protection, conscientization and so on. The major objectives of NGOs are as follows:

- Development of women and rural folks socially, economically, politically through income generating activities, education programmes, awareness camps, etc.
- General socio-economic development of the people living in rural areas especially in down-trodden areas.
- Encouraging the rural folks to participate actively in cultural activities, arts sports and science activities.
- Development of the under-privileged sections of the society such as fishermen tribal, rural women etc.
- Running educational programmes like formal education, non-formal education and adult education programmes to decrease illiteracy rate and to improve human resources for the development of a nation.
- Protecting the environment, rehabilitating the deprived sections like the handicapped, mentally retarded and orphans.
- Eradicating poverty through generation of employment opportunities, income generating activities, providing skill based training, imparting new technology in agriculture etc.
- Providing physical education, organizing competitions and giving training to the youth to participate actively in rural development activities.
- Initiating self-employment ventures for men and women and organizing leadership/personality development programmes.
- Propagating Gandhian ideology and literature, creating awareness and conducting de-addiction programmes.

- Formation of self help groups and to provide financial assistance to the members of SHGs in order to empower them economically,
- Doing research and surveys, working for social justice and offering legal advice to the rural and urban people who are in need of justice,
- Organizing mother and child care programmes and value based education sessions to decrease, child deaths, malnutrition of women at the time of pregnancy and children and improving health, hygiene and sanitation in slum areas.
- Protecting the interests of consumers and working for prohibition and assisting in housing.

GOALS OF NGOS : In essence, the goals of NGOs in Rural Development are:

- To help the people in their endeavors to progress;
- To promote the growth of inherent potentials among people;
- To initiate a process of participatory development;
- To bring about social justice for the poor and create awareness about their rights and duties;
- To promote growth in social, political and economic aspects of life in rural areas and
- To devise policies through networking with national and international agencies for sustainable development and facilitate the practice of the same.

Type of NGOs and their role in development activities:

NGOs adopt different vision, work style, approaches, composition and funding partnership. Based on these, different authors have classified them differently. While World Bank's operational directive (1989) classified NGOs into two broad categories viz; a) Operational, and b) Advocacy types depending on its perspective, NGOs can be classified into four categories from the Indian perspective.

Types of NGOs:

(a) Operational or Grassroots NGOs;

These work directly with the marginalized rural people. Along with charity and relief, they engage in following activities:

- **Welfare:** Providing facilities for education, health, drinking water, roads, etc.
- **Services:** Building up infrastructure in backward areas, facilitating credit supply of seeds and fertilizers, providing technological know-how, etc.
- **Development of socio-economic status:** Covering all people or concentrating on the poor in an area. Implementing projects related to income-generating activities, small saving schemes, micro-credit, adult education, mother and child health, etc.
- **Development of human beings:** Making people aware of rights, providing legal safeguards, checking corruption and exploitation, protecting human rights and enabling the poor for their development.

(b) Advocacy types of NGOs depending on its perspective:

(i) Support NGOs;

They provide services to strengthen grassroots NGOs and other agencies like Panchayati Raj Institutions and cooperatives for Rural Development preparing project proposals, providing training, disseminating information through publications, conducting research, and making evaluation studies. Occasionally, they provide financial support to grassroots NGOs. Some examples of such NGOs are Participatory Research in Asia, Voluntary Health Association of India, Xavier Institute of Social Service, etc

(ii) Network NGOs;

They are formal associations or informal groups of grassroots and/or support NGOs who meet periodically on particular local issues to promote or defend them. They reshape the agendas of donors by raising the local issues in national and international policy debate, lobbying and advocating, and thus contribute towards changing strategies for rural development. Some samples of such NGOs are Voluntary Action Network India, District Action Group in Odisha, Federation of the Voluntary Organization in Karnataka etc.

(iii) Funding NGOs;

These provide financial support to grassroots, support, and network NGOs. Such NGOs are national (CAPART in India) and international (IGSSS, USAID, FORD Foundation, etc.) agencies.

Though NGOs are classified into specific categories, they overlap in the first three categories and in their activities. A support or network NGO can also be a grassroots NGO or vice versa.

(iv) Grassroots Support and Network NGOs;

The main thrust areas of Council for Professional Social Workers (CPSW), with its headquarters at Bhubaneswar, are tribal development, sustainable livelihood, eco-regeneration, community health, promotion of child rights and education, gender equity, micro-credit, capacity building, and strengthening of community based organizations. It is working at present in eight tribal and dalit dominated districts of Odisha in integrated rural development projects geared towards sustainable livelihood. From 1993-96, CPSW was the first organization to start gender sensitization training programmes for development net-workers and government officials in the state of Odisha. It also provided training on watershed management. It campaigned and networked the state level NGOs for child labour reduction, research on environment and published its report for eco-regeneration and forest management in Odisha. Following the super cyclone in Odisha, it undertook relief and reconstruction programmes, built school-cum-cyclone shelter, distributed seeds and implemented cooperative cultivation. Being a grassroots NGO, it provides training and engages in advocacy and networking with other NGOs, researches for eco-regeneration, and emerges with new programmes depending upon the situation. Xavier Institute of Social Services located at Ranchi in Jharkhand state was established in 1955 with the vision to put the last first. As a support NGO, it provides training to grassroots NGOs, sensitizes local NGOs and people through documentations and publications, researches on various issues of the state, and prepares RD professionals through its professional educational programme. It networks the grassroots NGOs on various issues and implements RD projects

Objectives:

1. To understand the role of NGOs in sustainable development.
2. To analyze the effective participation of NGOs in sustainable development of India.
3. To find out the approaches to make effective participation of NGOs in rural development activities.

Research methodology:

Research is a systematic method to understand the phenomena and helps to analyze the concept of effective participation of NGOs in rural sustainable development. This paper is based on secondary source such as books, journals, reports and website resources. It helps to accomplish the objectives of this paper.

The role of NGOs in sustainable development:

Sustainable development is achieved through optimizing gains from several variables, rather than maximizing those from a single one. This requires government departments, by convention sectorally organized, to work together, or in some cases as a single multi-disciplinary authority. For this joint planning, transparency and coordination in implementation are required. The richness of skills available in society must be harnessed through partnerships involving institutions in civil society, such as NGOs, CBOs, corporate (including private) bodies, academic and research institutions, trade unions, etc., which must be made an integral part of planning and implementation for sustainable development.

NGO involvement is usually considered a late-twentieth-century phenomenon, but in fact it has occurred for over two centuries. The recent rate of proliferation of non-governmental organizations, however, is notable. NGOs are playing a promising interlocutors role in all development activities in existing academic as well as development studies. In recent times, responding to Grass-roots level initiative and voluntary action became necessary to develop the rural areas. The increasing demands for the NGOs are itself a response to recent trends relating to socio-economic issues and their corresponding development interventions in academic and policy-oriented research.

The role of NGOs in sustainable development of india:

In India since ancient times, social service has been an integral part of Indian culture. Soon after Independence, a number of NGOs had emerged in India. Mahatma Gandhi even pleaded to dissolve the Indian National Congress and transform it to a Lok Seva Sangh (Public Service Organization). Though his plea was rejected, but the followers of Mahatma Gandhi started many voluntary agencies to work on various social as well as economic issues of the country. This was the first phase of NGOs in India. The second phase of NGO development started in 1960 when it was felt that just the government programs were not sufficient to complete the task of development in rural areas. Many groups were formed whose role was to work at grass root levels. Moreover, favorable state policies had drastically affected the formation of NGOs and their roles at that time. Over the years, the role of NGOs in rural development of India increased. At present also, their role significantly increased with the change in the policies of the government through different plans.

In the sixth five-year plan (1980-1985), a new role for NGOs in the rural development had been identified by the government. In the seventh five-year plan (1985-1990), the Indian government envisaged an active role of NGOs in developing self-reliant communities. These groups were supposed to show how the village resources along with human resource, skill, local knowledge that is greatly underutilized could be used for their own development. As NGOs were working in close connection with local people so bringing such a change was not a tough task for them.

Accordingly, in the eighth five-year plan, more importance to NGOs for rural development in India had been given. Under this scheme, a nation-wide NGO network had been created. The role of these agencies was the rural development at a low cost.

In the ninth five-year plan, it has been proposed that NGOs would play a significant role in the development on the public-private partnership model. More scope has been provided to NGOs by the government for rural development through the agricultural development policies as well as their implementation mechanisms.

As with every five-year plan, the role of NGOs in the rural development of India is growing, so NGOs are now attracting professionals from different fields. NGOs act as planners and implementers of developmental plans. They help in mobilizing the local resources to be used for development. NGOs help in building a self-reliant and sustainable society. These agencies play the role of mediator between people and government. NGOs are actually the facilitator of development, education and professionalization. Thus roles that the NGOs perform today in India are numerous.

The role of NGOs in rural development activities :

The scope of development is not narrow but very wide, as it includes not just the economic development but the growth on social front, quality of life, empowerment, women and child development, education and awareness of its citizens. The task of development is so huge and complicated that just implementing government plans is not sufficient to fix the problem. To achieve this, a great vision and collaborative efforts involving various departments, agencies and even NGOs is required. Owing to such a great need, the number of NGOs in India is increasing rapidly and, at present, there are about 25,000 to 30,000 active NGOs in India.

Rural development seems to be a simple task but, in reality, it is not. Post Independence era has seen many rural development programmes through different five-year plans. Alleviating poverty, employment generation, more opportunities for generating income, and infrastructure facilities are emphasized through the policies and programmes of the government. Along with this, the panchayat raj institutions have also been initiated by the government to strengthen the democracy at grass roots level. But in spite of all the efforts rural poverty, unemployment rate, low production still exists. The fight is still on for the basic facilities such as livelihood security, sanitation problem, education, medical facilities, roads, etc. Still there is a huge gap in terms of infrastructure that is available in urban and rural areas. The basic rural development should include all these apart from employment, proper water supply and other basic facilities.

The NGOs are taking active participation in rural development. The rural poor and socially depressed classes are mainly depending upon the operations of NGOs. No particular job is particularly

meant for the NGOs. Thus, there is a huge competition among the NGOs to extend the services for the benefit of the poor. At the same time we should not forget the mushrooming of the NGOs for their welfare. The following are the important activities undertaken up for the development of the poor.

- **Agricultural related programs:** Numerous activities can be undertaken under agriculture sector. The jobs/projects like distributing planting materials, cattle, poultry, minor irrigation, free medical care for cattle's, safe drinking water for animals etc.
- **Health programmes for human and non-human beings:** The works like pit drainage, housing, creation of smokeless environment, good drinking water for animals and human beings, regular health checkup camps etc. will improve the health conditions of the human and non human beings.
- **Community development programs:** The community development programs like adoption of villages for development, moral support during flood and famine period, supply of food and drinking water during flood, common well, training programs for the rural youths, housing projects, repair and renovation of houses etc will satisfy the basic necessities. The important program like training programs for the rural poor will hold the youths from rural exodus. Even this type of training programs may also be extended for the rural women, so that we can expect self sustenance among this community.
- **Human Resource Development programs:** The personality development programs, skill development programs, educational programs, integrated development projects etc will enable the rural poor to earn bread and butter.
- **Trade and industrial promotion:** The important problem in the present context is availability of the market for the products of rural enterprises. Therefore, an NGO has a direct link with the government for marketing of the goods. Apart from this, NGO can also go for training the rural youths in fabrication works, wood works, beedi rolling, agarbathi manufacturing, printing press etc.
- **Government support:** The government (central, state or local) support at all level is inevitable for rural development. NGOs alone cannot do miracles over night. Therefore, the government should watch and ward the working of NGOs at phase wise manner. Thus, the fund or whatever may be directly should move to beneficiaries. The NGOs should accountable for the funds.

Barriers to rural development:

A major problem that NGOs are facing in India is their dependency upon government funds or external donations. With this dependency, NGOs are less flexible in carrying out their task as most of the tasks depend upon funds. Moreover, the structures of NGOs have become bureaucratic in nature leading to a decreased effectiveness in the overall development.

The traditional thinking of rural people, their poor understanding, low level of education for comprehending new technology and efforts, lack of awareness are people related hurdles that NGOs are facing. Villages also lack infrastructure facilities like water, electricity, educational institutes, communication facilities that leads to their slow development.

Apart from these, there are certain problems like economics such as high cost technology, underprivileged rural industries, social and cultural differences, conflicts between different groups, administrative problems like political interference, lack of motivation and interest act as hurdles on the way to rural development in India.

But in spite of all the hurdles, NGOs will keep on working for rural development in India. NGOs selectively utilized the local talent, train the individuals and use this for rural development. But the complete success of the rural development actually depends upon the willingness and active participation of rural people in the development processes and efforts. Further, NGOs should learn in employment generation in non-agricultural sectors which may play a crucial role in the rural development.

Major findings :

1. A few NGOs have been operating without proper direction, organizational development, good management practices and specific mission.
2. It is also observed from the existing literature that, some NGOs are very lack in the areas like decision-making for right kind of developmental intervention, managing socio-economic change and attaining sustainability,
3. There is a direct correlation between the donor funding and the continuation of the projects undertaken by NGOs in rural areas.
4. The major issue facing by the NGOs is the lack of qualified individuals who would like to work in the rural areas.

Suggestions:

The following suggestions and policy implications have been made for the further improvement in the working of NGOs.

1. A short-term training programme for strengthening the managerial capabilities of NGOs will go a long way in improving their performance and effectiveness significantly.
2. The over dependence of NGOs on funding agencies and the syndrome of dependency should be reduced by involving the government directly in funding activities.
3. Donor agencies should also take active initiation in selecting the funding projects and even selecting of NGOs too.
4. The donor agencies should go for surveying the viable projects for NGOs and the needs of the people.
5. NGO should also accept the truth that, the funding agencies are no longer available for the projects which are not viable.
6. Proper monitoring the activities of the NGOs and the enterprises run under the umbrella is the need of the hour.

Conclusion:

The overall analysis of the study highlights that the NGOs has an important role in promoting & implementing different development activities. NGOs are very prominent and effective in implementing sustainable rural development. There need practice the transparency and not only effective participation of the all members of the NGOs but also rural people participation. NGOs should encourage the rural people with the method of participatory rural appraisal and awareness activities. The government should take more interest and improve rural development with the help of NGOs. In this direction, the government should give support to NGOs.

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